constant ill health did not support these excursions. He had to quit and while fighting the illness, he dreamt of Jesus Christ. The tradition says that Jesus told him, ‘I’ll teach you.’

He gained mystic training and returned home at the age of twenty-nine. Then, he began to farm after having bought a piece of fertile land which soon began to give him a big yield. Not more than a decade later, he ended up getting more fertile lands, establishing businesses, popular Turkish baths and *Khānqahs*. He had also begun to send his trade caravans into China.[*] Many historians claim that he had become one of the richest men in Central Asia in that epoch.[†] It is said that most of his wealth was invested in religious endowments (*Waqf*). It is claimed that he had done abundant charity in this phase. He owned more than 3500 acres of cultivable land at one time.

Khwaja Ahrar had been extremely involved in the socio-economic activities of Transoxiana. Despite being born into a poor family, he became the richest man in the kingdom as he matured to a certain age.[‡] All dervishes of the time held him in high regard. Among the famous disciples, Maulana Abdur Rahman Jami was one of the important ones.[§] He learned most of the things under the counsel of his father. He was well guided by Khwaja Yaqub Charkhi in the later phase.[¶]

As the story goes, Ahrar had very strong characteristics of a *socialist*. He went to the Tīmūrid prince ruling at Samarkand to discuss the troubling conditions of the people. Sulṭān’s chief aid showed no interest and disallowed his entry into the court. Agitated Ahrar bragged, ‘I have been commanded by God and His messenger to come here.’ Still, Sulṭān’s aid showed no concern. Dejected, Ahrar then wrote the name of the Sulṭān on the wall and having erased it with his saliva said, ‘God will replace you with a King who is concerned for his people,’ and left.

Some days later, another Tīmūrid Sulṭān Abu Sa‘id Mīrzā (Babur’s grandfather), gathered his forces and attacked Samarkand thereby winning it for himself. This appeared like an opportunity to Khwaja Ahrar. This union of Abu Sa‘id Mīrzā and Khwaja Ahrar lasted for decades and proved to be fruitful for the whole kingdom. Khwaja had a strong influence on Abu Sa‘id’s family. He had given the name to Babur in his infancy as Zahiruddin Muhammad literally means, *Defender of Religion*.

Khwaja Ahrar often visited Abu and considered him to be no different from his son. Abu Sa‘id Mīrzā was quite a well-read person and appreciated art from the bottom of his heart. He had read the poems of Amir Khusrau, Nizami